while they themselves served as sounding boards.

As is the nature of the industry, the duo has faced enough setbacks too, and occasionally, sharp criticism. Despite the success of *Made in Heaven*, for instance, the second season of their series recently landed into a controversy after Dalit academic and author Yashica Dutt accused the creators of seeking inspiration from her life for an episode without giving her due credit. Zoya and Reema refuted the allegations. "We categorically deny any claim that Ms. Dutt's life or work was appropriated by us.... We will continue to platform stories and voices bigger than us," the statement read. The series has also had its share of critics, who dismiss the season as too "preachy" or "woke". But, says Reema in defence, "There's a larger chunk of people who need a bit of underlining." Whatever be the outcome of that criticism, amidst the maelstrom, the two have managed to accomplish what they set out to do—highlight their socio-cultural-political worldview and spark a conversation. "They know that to create characters that people connect with emotionally, one has to make them real and relatable," says Ritesh Sidhwani of Excel Entertainment.

Another way Zoya and Reema try to ensure that their work stays relevant is by being in step with ever-evolving cultural trends. And that goes beyond the world of films. It's not uncommon to spot them at gigs or exhibitions. "You can't have output without input," says Zoya. "Art feeds and enriches you. Otherwise, you are stuck in a loop and with the influences you grew up around. How else do you have your ear to the ground? It is not just all things new. I want to go to a museum and see something old"—and, "you don't know when something that's gone into the brain will come out and where," adds Reema.

It's what Tewari admires the most about them. "Many are culturally inclined for their personal growth, but very rarely do you see people translate it into their work," he says. "They have an interesting way of looking at music in what it's doing to the narrative and to you emotionally." The first album their music label released comprised lullabies. There's also Tiger Baby Digital for web shows and Tiger Telly for ad films. Zoya and Reema's friends joke that with their work rate, they'll soon be into petrochemicals. "Zoya is a bit of a workaholic. Every day, she has an idea about a new vertical," says Reema. "It's mine and Angad's job [Angad Dev Singh, CEO, Tiger Baby] to be like, 'Zoya, please calm down'."

As well-oiled a unit as they are, what hasn't materialised yet is a joint directorial project. The last time the pair tried to direct together, they were in their late 20s, and that attempt precipitated a month-long breakdown in communication. The joint directing credits seen in two episodes of the latest season of *Made in Heaven* were just clever deception. "We were never on the set together and OK-ing the same shot. Please, not at all!" says Zoya. Reema laughs. "We divided the episodes—those scenes are yours and these are mine." Could the impossible happen someday? "I don't know. I love Zoya. I love myself. I don't want to put ourselves in a situation where we will kill each other," says Reema. What they won't stop doing together is sound the clapboard for the first shot of each other's films. And chat about their beloved pets—two beagles each. And write. And, of course, do a whole lot of *mandavali*. ■

IN THE PIPELINE



↘ THE ARCHIES
Releasing on Dec. 7 on Netflix

Collaborating with Ayesha DeVitre, Zoya and Reema adapt the popular comic series into a film about the cultural backdrop of the Anglo-Indian community of the 1960s. Research included extensive interviews with members and reading books about Landour and McCluskieganj to capture the period's essence

↘ SUPERMEN OF MALEGAON, *2024*

As a fan of Faiza Ahmad Khan's delightful documentary on the Malegaon film industry, Zoya met one of its key subjects, Nasir Sheikh, who is among Malegaon's most prolific filmmakers. "He was like, 'I am a big fan of your father, I have copied all his work'," Zoya recalled of the encounter. "It was the sweetest thing in the world that he was so proud of this." The duo has got stand-up comic, lyricist and filmmaker Varun Grover on board as writer for this project, with Reema donning the directing cap

↘ KHO GAYE HUM KAHAAN, *2024*

The film marks the first time that their banner Tiger Baby launches a director in Arjun Varain Singh, who had served as director's assistant for Zoya on *Gully Boy*. The three have written *Kho Gaye Hum Kahaan* together, which features Adarsh Gourav, Siddhanth Chaturvedi and Ananya Panday